

ONLY UNITE Ghulam Nabi Azad announces plans for his new party at a rally in Jammu on September 4

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KASHMIR

GHULAM SEEKS HIS AZADI

general secretary of the All India Youth Congress. Before his appointment, so the talk goes in J&K Congress circles, Wani was taken into confidence by Rahul as they had got a whiff of Azad's plan to break away and form his own party. Wani's appointment, say Congress insiders, is also aimed at ending the factionalism that has beset J&K Congress. One faction was said to be centred around Ghulam Ahmed Mir, the JKPCC president from whom Wani took over. Mir, too, had earned the trust of the Gandhi family, which did not go down well with Azad. "He (Azad) was surrounded by a coterie. He was the reason for factionalism," says a senior Congress leader. "His exit is a loss but will end factionalism and help us focus on growth."

Ever since Azad's Rajya Sabha term ended in February 2021, rumours about his exit and a possible breakaway party were doing the rounds. Though Azad had declared them false, Wani says the ex-CM has held 10 meetings to discuss a new party since last year. "When Congress lost the Punjab assembly election, he wanted to time his party's launch with that. But Sonia held a meeting with the G-23 group. The issues raised by some leaders were addressed and Azad sahib, too, was given some promise of a Rajya Sabha renomination. But he continued the meetings about a new party," reveals Wani.

Salman Nizami, an aide of Azad, presents the other perspective. Pointing to the Congress's decimation in Punjab and other state assembly polls, he says it only ended up dividing secular votes—citing Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal, where the Congress fielded candidates against the Samajwadi Party and the Trinamool Congress. "The Congress has lost election after election. They did not listen to Azad sahib's suggestions and he felt humiliated when his recommendation that G.M. Saroori be appointed J&K Congress president was rejected," says Nizami. "Vikar is inexperienced. Azad sahib wanted someone who could unite the Congress." As for Azad charting his own path, his aide justifies it saying: "He is popular among both Muslims and Hindus."

The hitherto non-controversial Azad, who shared cordial ties across the political spectrum, faces a primary allegation from the Congress: to wit, that he's become 'Modi's man' and is tasked with hurting his old party. Nizami flatly denies the accusation, pointing to Azad's statement that he would not align with the BJP. "We will fight the BJP with secular parties. If a secular party is strong in a particular constituency, we would rethink fielding a candidate," he says.

At Kashmir University, a political analyst pleading anonymity stresses that Azad's entry at the head of a new outfit at a time when elections are overdue in the erstwhile state will prove crucial. He says Azad may impact the political landscape in Jammu, where his party can fragment the Muslim vote, especially in the Muslim-majority Chenab and Pir Panjal regions. "This new journey will be crucial for his career too, as it can determine his fate," he says. "Else, he can end up like [former Punjab chief minister] Amarinder Singh." ■

INSIDERS SAY AZAD LEFT BECAUSE THE HIGH COMMAND IGNORED HIS PREFERRED CANDIDATES FOR THE POST OF JKPCC CHIEF